

5.1 Myths About Computer Viruses

As we have said before, all the suspicious activity that happens on your computer cannot be blamed on viruses. There could be many reasons why your PC has been acting up, such as applications clashing, missing files, hardware incompatibility and much more. There are a lot of myths and false notions that people seem to have towards viruses and their solutions. This section hopes to shed light on some common misconceptions.

Only Microsoft operating systems get viruses

Most virus writers want their work to be famous and get world-wide recognition. With the majority of the world using Microsoft operating systems, there are no prizes for guessing why most malicious code is written for them. There are viruses for Macintosh and Linux computers as well, though not as many.

If the EXE attachment is from someone I know, surely it's safe

Just because you know the person, doesn't mean that the person is aware of the mails he's forwarding. He could unknowingly be forwarding an infected attachment without realizing it, or it could be a worm on his computer spreading its code to everyone on his address book.

The worm can't hurt me if I don't open the attachment

We only wish it was that simple. Today, most worms can infect your computer and then spread to all your contacts even if you just open the mail that contains the worm. You need to pay attention to the subject line of the message.

Installing an antivirus guarantees my protection

Absolutely not! Depending on the kind of antivirus package you have, it may have its own strengths and weaknesses. With viruses getting smarter by the day, there's a strong chance that the latest batch may be undetectable for the antivirus' heuristics system.

I don't use an e-mail client, so I'm safe from e-mail viruses

Though this may be true to a small extent, it's not a foregone conclusion. Yes, using an e-mail client does give a virus the opportu-